

Precautions

A Precautions are used to ensure safety, to prevent damage to equipment and breaches of security, to ensure the law is not broken. Anyone using the internet should exercise some basic precautions. A precautionary statement is a phrase that describes the recommended measure(s) to minimise or prevent adverse effects of reckless or criminal acts. Examples of precautionary statements include:

- Avoid opening suspicious emails.
- Check links before you click.
- Always scan external devices for malware before accessing them.

B If there is any reason to fear the precaution may not be understood, a reason for the warning may be added:

- **Security is very important.** Don't forget to change your password regularly.

C We usually use an imperative in the positive or negative form to give precautions and make suggestions:

- **Back up** important data.
- Only **store** sensitive information in secure places.
- **Don't use** out-of-date anti-virus software.

We use modal verbs like **should/shouldn't**, **can/cannot**, etc. to give orders, advice and warnings:

- There **should** be a limit for password attempts.
- Passwords **cannot** consist of easily guessed or obtained personal information.
- You **can** enable two-factor authentication for added security.

Precautions may be made stronger by using **must/must not**:

- Cybersecurity measures **must** constantly adjust to new technologies and developments.

We can use conditionals to talk about warnings and threats. The *if*-clause usually introduces the condition (risk factor(s)), while the main clause contains advice.

- If you are unsure about the security of a website, you can contact the website's customer service to ask about their security measures.
- You should make sure to back up your data regularly to protect it from loss in case a malware attack or other disaster occurs.

We can use a pattern with **it + be + adjective/noun + clause**.

- **It's best** to rid your computer of all forms of adware to maintain your privacy.
- When using the internet, **it is important** to be careful about what you click on and download.
- **It's a good idea** to know how to recognize cybercrime.
- **It's smart** to know how to protect your identity even when travelling.